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VOL. 8 · ST. DAVID

The Prime Minister's Fortress

The NNP held St. David from 2013 to 2022. Dickon Mitchell took it in 2022 by 1,672 votes and held it in 2026 by 3,180. The NNP did not win a single polling division. Here is what an opposition can and cannot do against a prime minister at home.

BY GREG HOSTEN

ST. DAVID, GRENADA

ST. DAVID, GRENADA—St. David is the Prime Minister's seat, and on 5th November it behaved like one. Dickon Mitchell took 5,318 votes to 2,138 for the NNP's Noleen James-Thompson, a majority of 3,180, the largest in the country. The NNP won 28.7 per cent of the two-party vote and did not carry a single polling division.

> **"A seat that cannot be won in 2030 can still be contested, and prepared for the day it opens."**
> GREG HOSTEN

It was not always like this. The NNP's Oliver Joseph held St. David from 2013 until 2022 and served as Foreign Minister. Four years ago the seat changed hands when the NDC's new leader chose to stand there. Since then the NDC's majority has almost doubled.

HOW A LEADER TAKES A SEAT

In December 2021, five weeks after he was elected NDC leader, Mr. Mitchell announced that he would contest St. David. The party's existing caretaker stood aside. In June 2022 Mr. Mitchell beat Mr. Joseph by 4,414 votes to 2,742, taking 61.7 per cent of the two-party vote.

A party leader brings resources no ordinary candidate can match: national media attention, a campaign machine and, once in office, the visible authority of government. In 2026 Mr. Mitchell stood as a sitting prime minister. His vote rose by 904.

A CARETAKER WITH 19 MONTHS

The NNP named Noleen James-Thompson as its caretaker for St. David on 23rd April 2025, one of four new caretakers presented that day for seats lost in 2022. She had about 19 months before polling day to introduce herself to more than 11,000 voters, against a prime minister.

That was never a fair fight, and nobody in the party should pretend it was. But the scale of the defeat still matters. The NNP's vote fell by 604, from 2,742 to 2,138. Its share of the two-party vote fell from 38.3 to 28.7 per cent.

CLOSE TO THE NATIONAL SWING

The fall of 9.6 points in the NNP's two-party share is slightly smaller than the national swing of 10.3 points. In other words, the NNP did not do unusually badly in St. David. It did about as badly as everywhere else, from a much lower starting point.

That is a useful finding. It suggests that the Prime Minister's personal pull in his own seat was largely in place by 2022, and that the movement since then followed the national tide. The NNP's problem in St. David is not a local collapse. It is a long-standing deficit that the party has not begun to close.

NOT ONE POLLING DIVISION

The polling-division results show the depth of the NDC's hold. The NNP did not win any division in St. David. Its best result was at the Berean Pre-School in Marlmount, where it took 39.1 per cent of the two-party vote across two divisions. At Pomme Rose it took 35.5 per cent.

Its worst results were stark. At the St. David's R.C. School the NNP took 16.1 per cent, 50 votes to 261. At St. Theresa's R.C. School in Vincennes it took 20.3 per cent. At Westerhall Secondary School, across four divisions, 27.2 per cent. At Corinth, across four divisions, 29.3 per cent.

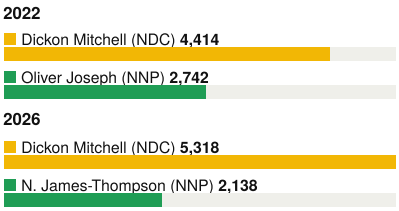
GROWTH, AND WHO FOUND IT

St. David's register grew by 1,444 names between 2022 and 2026, the largest increase of any seat. Only 293 more ballots were cast, and turnout fell from 72.9 to 66.2 per cent. This year 3,828 registered voters did not vote.

The NDC added 904 votes. The NNP lost 604. Measured against the whole electorate,

2022 VS 2026

Votes by candidate, in party colours



3,180 votes

NDC winning margin in 2026

BY THE NUMBERS

3,180

NDC winning margin, the largest of all 15 seats

0

Polling divisions won by the NNP

+1,444

Growth in the register since 2022, the most of any seat

−604

Fall in the NNP vote since 2022

the NDC won the votes of 47.0 per cent of all registered voters, and the NNP 18.9 per cent. Nearly half the electorate actively voted for the Prime Minister.

WHAT THE NUMBERS SAY IS POSSIBLE

To have won St. David, the NNP would have needed 1,591 voters to switch sides, or 3,181 new supporters, more than four in five of everyone who stayed home. That is not achievable in one election against a sitting prime minister, and a serious plan should say so.

But a seat that cannot be won can still be contested. Every vote the NNP adds in St. David counts in its national share, which fell to 37.7 per cent this year. A constituency of 11,310 voters is too large to abandon. And prime ministers do not stay in office forever: when Mr. Mitchell eventually steps down, St. David will be an open seat, and the party that has been present throughout will be best placed to take it.

WHAT CAN BE DONE: AN EIGHT-YEAR PLAN FOR ST. DAVID

St. David needs a plan measured in two elections, not one. Its first goal is to narrow the gap, and its second is to be ready when the seat opens.

Years one and two, 2027 to 2028: confirm a candidate who will commit to St. David for at least two elections, so that voters see continuity rather than a new name every cycle. Open a permanent office. Begin with Marlmount and Pomme Rose, where the NNP is strongest, and build outwards.

Years three and four, 2029 to 2030: recruit a captain for every polling division. Hold the Prime Minister to account in public on what St. David itself has received, measured against his promises. Set realistic targets: win back the 604 NNP votes lost since 2022, and lift the party's share above 35 per cent.

Beyond 2030: keep the office open and the candidate in place. The NNP held St. David for nine years until 2022. Seats that change hands with a leader can change back when the leader goes, but only for a party that never left.

THE LESSON FOR EVERY NNP SEAT

Not every seat is winnable in one election, and a serious party says so plainly. St. David is the clearest example in this series. But a seat that cannot be won in 2030 can still add votes to the national total, train volunteers, and prepare for the day it opens.

The NNP's recent habit has been to name caretakers late in seats it does not expect to win. In St. David that produced a candidate with 19 months against a prime minister. The alternative is to treat hard seats as long-term investments, with the same candidate and the same office for eight years.

THE ARITHMETIC OF ST. DAVID

Measure	2022	2026	Change
NNP votes	2,742	2,138	−604
NDC votes	4,414	5,318	+904
NNP share of two-party vote	38.3%	28.7%	−9.6 pts
NNP two-party share nationally	48.0%	37.7%	−10.3 pts
Winning margin	NDC +1,672	NDC +3,180	largest of 15 in 2026
Registered voters	9,866	11,310	+1,444
Turnout	72.9%	66.2%	−6.7 pts
Registered voters who did not vote	2,677	3,828	+1,151
NNP votes as a share of all registered voters	27.8%	18.9%	−8.9 pts
Polling divisions won by the NNP		0	
Switchers the NNP needed to win		1,591	

Two-party figures exclude minor candidates (2022: IFP 18). 2026 figures are provisional results from the Parliamentary Elections Office.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR 2030/31

1. Be honest about hard seats: St. David cannot be won in one election.
2. Contest it anyway: every vote counts toward the national share.
3. Commit to one candidate for two elections, not a new name each cycle.
4. Name caretakers early: 19 months is too short against a prime minister.
5. Build out from Marlmount and Pomme Rose, the NNP's best ground.
6. Win back the 604 NNP votes lost since 2022.
7. Keep a permanent office open between elections.
8. Prepare for the day the seat opens: leaders do not stay forever.

Sources: Parliamentary Elections Office live results, live.elections.gd (2026, provisional; polling divisions read 9 Nov 2026); Wikipedia (2022 general election; Oliver Joseph); NOW Grenada (Mitchell to contest St. David, Dec 2021; NNP caretakers, 23 Apr 2025; 2026 results); Caribbean Focus (NNP caretakers, Apr 2025). Analytics computed by the author from the published counts. Analysis by Greg Hosten, Vol. 8 of a weekly constituency series. Written in the style of a newspaper report; not a publication of any news organisation.